shifting contexts. After 1989, these artists powerfully adapted their approaches, embarking on new projects with a set of questions probing the redefining of the United States and Germany as each shifted away from Cold War dynamics. Without anticipation or telos, the American Berliners of this book also offered post-1989 reflections and works that focused on emergent forms of collective memory in Berlin, to gather additional histories and mark uneven flows of progress amid the spectacle of the border's dismantling.

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In the spring and summer of 1989, due to public pressures from within, both at the party level and from grassroots activists, the ruling regimes of the Eastern bloc loosened expressive restrictions and select border controls. Each increment of change was spurred by a series of economic and social reforms in the wake of Soviet policies of *Glasnost* and *Perestroika*.[1] In East Germany, citizens in Leipzig protested the policies of one-party rule. Earlier that same year, on January 18, East German party leader Erich Honecker had promised a more advanced Berlin Wall that could stand for "fifty or a hundred years, if the reasons for its existence have not been removed."[2] But by July 1989, over 25,000 East Germans had fled through the recently opened Hungarian border. As the option to defect through Hungary emerged, the idea of change was also afoot for the large number of East Germans who intended to stay in the German Democratic Republic. Inspired and emboldened by the changing and increasingly public nature of dissidence, these citizens felt emboldened to reshape the government. The large and growing gatherings of protestors sought to reform the existing system, with demands including greater access to travel without danger of reprimand or retribution.[3] In the fall, a weekly Monday protest movement in Leipzig quickly swelled. The protest movement spread across East German cities. By October 30, approximately 300,000 citizens marched in Leipzig. That same night, 20,000 East Berliners also took to their streets. These public displays remained overwhelmingly peaceful and yet emphatically called for change, signaling the imminent demise of the regime. The ruling authorities of the GDR began planning reforms to quell the outrage but had to act fast due to the expanding public spectacle of the uprisings.[4]

On November 9, 1989, at six o' clock in the evening local time, a media spokesperson for the East German authorities, Günter Schabowski, read a report to television reporters of the regime's reform plans prompted as a